A Selection of the Hardest Role Questions

Take a look at the following questions. Try to go through the questions practicing the skills developed earlier in the chapter. Try to follow the steps as I have outlined above, paying special attention to the answer choices! Do the questions first before looking at my explanations!

Again, if you find yourself struggling with some of the questions, don't worry too much about timing. Use the opportunity to develop a systematic approach to these types of questions, fill in knowledge gaps, and familiarize yourself with how to decipher an abstract answer choice. For the advanced test taker, try to aim for under 3 minutes per question, 2 minutes per question is really good, granted that you are getting them correct and following the steps.

Structurally analyzing the stimulus is the first step to successfully tackling Role questions. In fact, complicated arguments with multiple premises, intermediate conclusions, and background information is the most common characteristic of harder Role questions.

> **Difficult Trait #1:** Make sure you are clearly categorizing each statement that appears in the stimulus and argument as you are reading it. Don't confuse the intermediate conclusion for the main conclusion.

PT34 S3 Q14

[People's political behavior frequently does not match their rhetoric.] Although many complain about government intervention in their lives, [they tend not to re-elect inactive politicians.] But a politician's activity consists largely in the passage of laws whose enforcement affects voters' lives. Thus, voters often re-elect politicians whose behavior they resent.

Which one of the following most accurately describes the role played in the argument by the claim that people tend not to re-elect inactive politicians?

A. It describes a phenomenon for which the argument's conclusion is offered as an explanation

B. It is a premise offered in support of the conclusion that voters often re-elect politicians whose behavior they resent

C. It is offered as an example of how a politician's activity consists largely in the passage of laws whose enforcement interferes with voters' lives

D. It is a generalization based on the claim that people complain about government intervention in their lives

E. It is cited as evidence that people's behavior never matches their political beliefs

Let's break this question down step by step:

First things first, let's make a note of what is it exactly that we are going to analyze in this question:

> **People's political behavior frequently does not match their rhetoric. Although many complain about government intervention in their lives, they tend not to re-elect inactive politicians. But a politician's activity consists largely in the passage of laws whose enforcement affects voters' lives. Thus, voters often re-elect politicians whose behavior they resent.**

Which one of the following most accurately describes the role played in the argument by the claim that people tend not to re-elect inactive politicians?

So it's the second half of the second statement that we are concerned with, let's now break down the stimulus structurally.

Statement 1: *People's political behavior frequently does not match their rhetoric*

This can be an opinion of the authors, or it can be an observation. At this point it can either be used for support or supported by another statement. Let's keep on reading and try to situate this statement when we have more information.

Statement 2: *Although many complain about government intervention in their lives, they tend not to re-elect inactive politicians*

This statement seems like a further development of the first statement. It offers more details. So people say they want governments to leave them alone, but they don't like politicians who don't do anything. (In other words, politicians who actually do leave them alone don't get any support.)

It seems to me that statement 1 is a summary of what statement 2 is actually describing. Statement 2 seems like a premise at the moment, maybe statement 1 is the conclusion or intermediate conclusion. Let's keep on going.

Statement 3: *But a politician's activity consists largely in the passage of laws whose enforcement affects voters' lives*

Stop and think. How does this piece of information tie in with what we have read and gathered previously? In statement 2 we said that voters say they don't like interference, but don't vote for inactive politicians. This statement is saying what political activities are; in other words, what active politicians do. Active politicians interfere in voters' lives. Inactive politicians don't get the votes, active ones do. So voters say they don't want interference but will go on to vote for interfering politicians.

Statement 2 and 3 are definitely premises. Statement 1 seems like the conclusion so far, let's

take a look at the last sentence.

Statement 4: *Thus, voters often re-elect politicians whose behavior they resent*

How the last statement is presented should already be familiar to the discerning student. It's the last statement and begins with "thus". It could signify the actual conclusion of the argument, but we must remember that often the test makers will present an intermediate conclusion this way. So always make sure. Here it is the intermediate conclusion, while the first statement is in fact the conclusion. Here is the argument in simplified form:

- **Premise 1:** People want governments to leave them alone, but they don't vote for politicians who are inactive. (Assumption: It's the active politicians who get the votes)
- **Premise 2:** Active politicians don't leave people alone.
- **Intermediate Conclusion:** People end up voting for politicians that do things they don't like (interference).
- **Conclusion:** What people say (leave me alone!) don't match what they do (vote for interfering politicians).

Now let's think about the relationship between the underlined statement and the conclusion, and how the underlined statement functions in the author's argument.

Before approaching the answer choices, we have come to an understanding that the statement in question is a premise, the argument contains two premises, an intermediate conclusion, and a main conclusion.

Now for the hard part, differentiating between answer choices:

A. It describes a phenomenon for which the argument's conclusion is offered as an explanation

We have seen this kind of structure before, once in the previous chapter on Find the Conclusion questions, and again in the exercise earlier in the chapter. A phenomenon is presented, and a cause is provided. Why is John grumpy? It's because he didn't have his morning coffee. Why is David late? Because his car broke down. The statement in question is not a phenomenon that the conclusion provides the cause for. If the argument in the stimulus read like this, then A would be the correct answer:

> Voters tend not to re-elect inactive politicians. This is because people forget about politicians who haven't done anything and people vote for those that have made a strong impression.

B. It is a premise offered in support of the conclusion that voters often re-elect politicians whose behavior they resent

Looks good on a first pass: it is indeed a premise, and it is supporting the (intermediate) conclusion that voters often re-elect politicians whose behavior they resent. But the premise is calling the intermediate conclusion an "argument as a whole", is that grounds for elimination?

Remember this answer choice from our exercise earlier?

It is the conclusion of the argument as a whole but is not the only explicitly stated conclusion in the argument

On the LSAT, the word "conclusion" can refer to both the main conclusion and the intermediate conclusion. "Conclusion of the argument as a whole" means main conclusion. So while the wording of this question should raise some eyebrows, it's not wrong per se.

C. It is offered as an example of how a politician's activity consists largely in the passage of laws whose enforcement interferes with voters' lives

Active politicians interfere with voters' lives is the message of the next statement, this statement is about voters not re-electing inactive politicians.

D. It is a generalization based on the claim that people complain about government intervention in their lives

> ## Generalizations and Examples are related concepts.
>
> In an LSAT stimulus, a generalization is when you infer a rule based on specific facts/findings. If I saw 500 swans and they were all white, I can generalize by saying that all swans are white. Conversely, I can have a rule that I back up with a specific example. I can say that as a general rule, people who work hard on the LSAT will succeed. For example, John studied 10 hours a day for a year, and he got a 180.

So a "generalization based on the claim that people complain about government intervention in their lives" should look something like this:

All my neighbors complain about government interference, all my coworkers too: so people tend to complain when they perceive government intervention in their lives.

E. It is cited as evidence that people's behavior never matches their political beliefs

Two things I dislike about this answer: one, the conclusion is about people's behavior not matching rhetoric. So what they do doesn't match up with what they say. It's not about what they believe. Two, "never" is too strong a word here, remember to be careful with answer choices that are too strong. Degree based errors are frequent in wrong answer choices.

The correct answer is B.

PT70 S4 Q24

Biologist: Scientists have discovered fossilized bacteria in rocks 3.5 billion years old. The fossils indicate that these bacteria were quite complex and so must have already had a long evolutionary history when fossilized 3.5 billion years ago. However, Earth is only 4.6 billion years old, so the first life on Earth must have appeared soon after the planet's formation, when conditions were extremely harsh. This suggests that life may be able to arise under many

difficult conditions throughout the universe.

Which one of the following most accurately describes the role played in the biologist's argument by the claim that fossilized bacteria discovered in rocks 3.5 billion years ago must have had a long evolutionary history?

A. It is a claim for which no support is provided in the argument, and that is used to illustrate the conclusion of the argument as a whole

B. It is a claim for which no support is provided in the argument, and that itself is used to support a claim that in turn lends support to the conclusion of the argument as a whole

C. It is a claim for which some support is provided in the argument, and that itself is used to support another claim that in turn lends support to the conclusion of the argument as a whole

D. It is a claim for which some support is provided in the argument, and that itself is not used to support any other claim in the argument

E. It is a claim for which some support is provided in the argument, and that itself is used to support two distinct conclusions, neither of which is intended to provide support for the other

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Let's take this question apart:

Biologist: Scientists have discovered fossilized bacteria in rocks 3.5 billion years old. The fossils indicate that these bacteria were quite complex and so must have already had a long evolutionary history when fossilized 3.5 billion years ago. However, Earth is only 4.6 billion years old, so the first life on Earth must have appeared soon after the planet's formation, when conditions were extremely harsh. This suggests that life may be able to arise under many difficult conditions throughout the universe.

Notice how I only underlined the second half of the second statement. This is because the second statement actually contains two pieces of information: "bacteria were complex" AND that "they must have had a long evolutionary history". The question is asking about the part regarding "long evolutionary history", it never mentioned the "complex" part. So the lesson is to always focus on exactly what the question is asking about, never just automatically assume we are looking at the entire sentence in which our underlined statement is situated.

What is the structure of the author's argument?

The conclusion is the last sentence of the stimulus: life may arise under difficult conditions in the universe.

How is this conclusion supported? Let's take a look at the rest of the stimulus.

Statement 1: *Scientists have discovered fossilized bacteria in rocks 3.5 billion years old.*

This is a fact and most likely background information, let's continue.

Statement 2: *The fossils indicate that these bacteria were quite complex and so must have already had a long evolutionary history when fossilized 3.5 billion years ago.*

Careful with this one, it may only be one sentence but there's a lot of information involved. So the bacteria were complex, so they must have had a long evolutionary history. There is a mini-argument here! The author is probably assuming that the complexity of a bacteria means that it has had a long time to develop. So even within this sentence, there is both a premise and an intermediate conclusion.

Premise (bacteria were complex) + Assumption (more complex the bacteria, more time they had to evolve) → Intermediate Conclusion (these bacteria had already been around for a long time when they fossilized 3.5 billion years ago)

Statement 3: *However, Earth is only 4.6 billion years old, so the first life on Earth must have appeared soon after the planet's formation, when conditions were extremely harsh.*

On a first glance, we may not clearly see how this relates to the information we have read previously. Remember statement 2 had said that the bacteria had been around for a long time. They fossilized 3.5 billion years ago, so they must have been much older than that. If Earth is only 4.6 billion years old, and the bacteria have been around a lot longer than 3.5 billion years, then we can infer that the bacteria has been around soon after earth was formed.

Statement 3 also contains a piece of new information, namely that conditions were harsh when earth was just formed.

As we said before, the last statement, "life may be able to arise under many difficult conditions throughout the universe", is the conclusion. Because bacteria appeared under harsh conditions on earth, the author concludes that life can arise under harsh conditions in the universe.

This argument is structurally quite complex, if we diagram it out we get this:

I've paraphrased the underlined statement (bacteria must have had a long evolutionary history when they fossilized 3.5 billion years ago) for ease of understanding. This statement, as the diagram makes clear, is right in the middle of the argument chain. It has support, which makes it an intermediate conclusion; but it is also supporting another intermediate conclusion down the road. Let's take a look at the answer choices:

A. It is a claim for which no support is provided in the argument, and that is used to illustrate the conclusion of the argument as a whole

Does our statement have support in the argument? It's easily missed but it's still there: because the bacteria were complex, so they must have a long evolutionary history. The complexity of the bacteria is the support. Is it an illustration (example) of the main conclusion? No.

B. It is a claim for which no support is provided in the argument, and that itself is used to support a claim that in turn lends support to the conclusion of the argument as a whole

Same problem as the previous answer choice, there is support for the claim. The rest of the answer has no problems with it, but that only makes it a partially correct answer.

C. It is a claim for which some support is provided in the argument, and that itself is used to support another claim that in turn lends support to the conclusion of the argument as a whole

Support is indeed provided, and the statement is being used to support Intermediate Conclusion #2, which further supports the main conclusion.

D. It is a claim for which some support is provided in the argument, and that itself is not used to support any other claim in the argument

The only statement that is not being used to support anything else in an argument is the main conclusion. What D is referring to here is the main conclusion.

E. It is a claim for which some support is provided in the argument, and that itself is used to support two distinct conclusions, neither of which is intended to provide support for the other

This is describing an intermediate conclusion, and the stimulus described in this answer choice has two separate main conclusions. It is similar to answer choice E of the previous question, and does not fit with our understanding of this question's stimulus.

The correct answer is C.

PT70 S1 Q17

Meteorologist: Heavy downpours are likely to become more frequent if Earth's atmosphere becomes significantly warmer. A warm atmosphere heats the oceans, leading to faster evaporation, and the resulting water vapor forms rain clouds more quickly. A warmer atmosphere also holds more moisture, resulting in larger clouds. In general, as water vapor in larger clouds condenses, heavier downpours are more likely to result.

Which one of the following most accurately describes the role played in the meteorologist's argument by the claim that, in general, as water vapor in larger clouds condenses, heavier downpours are more likely to result?

A. It is the only conclusion in the argument

B. It is the conclusion of the argument as a whole but is not the only explicitly stated conclusion in the argument

C. It is a statement that the argument is intended to support but is not the conclusion of the argument as a whole

D. It is used to support the only conclusion in the argument

E. It provides a causal explanation of the phenomenon described by the conclusion of the argument as a whole, but it is not intended to provide support for that conclusion

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Before we dive into this question, I just wanted to return to the topic of causality vs argument structure and develop it further. It's a subject which confuses even the most advanced students.

Remember how we mentioned that if there is a cause and effect relationship in a LR argument, don't automatically assume that the cause is the premise and effect is the conclusion? Take a quick look at the following example:

> John couldn't wake up on time for his morning class. John usually has trouble waking up in the morning when he stays up late watching Netflix. Therefore John probably has been binge watching Netflix again last night.

What is the cause and effect relationship here? Watching Netflix (Cause) → Cannot wake up early (Effect)

What are the premises and conclusion of this mini argument?

- **Premise 1:** John couldn't wake up early
- **Premise 2:** John has trouble waking up early when he watches Netflix late into the night
- **Conclusion:** John was probably watching Netflix last night

So we know to analyze the logical aspect of a LR argument (in this case, causality) separate from its structure (premise/conclusion). But when we have a causational chain in the argument, that's when things get even more confusing. Take a look at the following example:

> Because Megan missed her morning coffee she was not paying attention to her surroundings. As a result she fell down the stairs on her way to school. So not getting your daily dose of caffeine can cause dangerous accidents.

The cause/effect chain is pretty obvious here:

No Coffee (A) → Not Paying Attention to Surroundings (B) → Accident (C)

But structurally, how should we diagram this argument?

We know that the conclusion is A → C, and we have two pieces of information supporting that conclusion: A → B and B → C. Is there an intermediate conclusion here?

Remember that the intermediate conclusion is ALWAYS supported by a premise? Does A → B support in any way B → C? No. They are two independent causal relationships. Yes it's true that they form the same causal chain in our argument. But there is no supporting relationship between the two.

So structurally, what we have essentially is this:

- **Premise:** A → B
- **Premise:** B → C
- **Conclusion:** A → C

Just because there is a causal logic chain, A → B → C, doesn't mean that A is the premise, B the intermediate conclusion, and C the conclusion!

If the argument is in conditional form, the essential difference between an argument's structure and its logic is still there:

> *If you went to Yale Law School, then you must have gotten a great LSAT score. Every high LSAT scorer is a proficient computer user. So all YLS students are proficient computer users.*

Conditionally: YLS $\rightarrow$ Great LSAT $\rightarrow$ Computer Skills

Structurally:

Premise: YLS $\rightarrow$ Great LSAT

Premise: Great LSAT $\rightarrow$ Computer Skills

Conclusion: YLS $\rightarrow$ Computer Skills

Is "Great LSAT $\rightarrow$ Computer Skills" an intermediate conclusion? No. Because the conditional premise "YLS $\rightarrow$ Great LSAT" is not supporting "Great LSAT $\rightarrow$ Computer Skills". They are each independent premises, when combined, lead to the conclusion.

In other words, just because a statement/idea/condition forms the middle part of a causal or conditional chain, that doesn't make it the intermediate conclusion. Always treat the structure of an argument (premise, intermediate conclusion, main conclusion) and the logical aspects of the argument (cause/effect, sufficient/necessary) as two distinct and separate issues!

So Cause—---> Effect is not the same thing as Premise → Conclusion!

Similarly, Sufficient $\rightarrow$ Necessary is also not the same thing as Premise – Conclusion.

With that in mind, let's break up the stimulus' structure.

Statement 1: Heavy downpours are likely to become more frequent if Earth's atmosphere

becomes significantly warmer.

Warmer atmosphere $\Rightarrow$ More frequent heavy downpours

Statement 2: A warm atmosphere heats the oceans, leading to faster evaporation, and the resulting water vapor forms rain clouds more quickly

Warm atmosphere $\Rightarrow$ Hotter ocean $\Rightarrow$ Faster evaporation $\Rightarrow$ Faster rain cloud formation

Statement 3: A warmer atmosphere also holds more moisture, resulting in larger clouds

Warm atmosphere $\Rightarrow$ More moisture $\Rightarrow$ Larger clouds

Statement 4: In general, as water vapor in larger clouds condenses, heavier downpours are more likely to result

Larger clouds $\Rightarrow$ More frequent heavy downpours

Let’s reorganize the information in structural form:

Premise 1: Warm atmosphere $\Rightarrow$ Faster rain cloud formation

Premise 2: Warm atmosphere $\Rightarrow$ Larger clouds

Premise 3: Larger clouds $\Rightarrow$ More frequent heavy downpours

Conclusion: Warm atmosphere $\Rightarrow$ More frequent heavy downpours

The statement we are analyzing is the last statement of the stimulus, and as we have seen, is a premise (Premise 3).

The correct answer is D.

In the next question, practice not only reading the argument for its structure, but also pay specific attention to the keywords in each answer choice.

> **Difficult Trait #2:** Be extra careful of vague/abstract terms in answer choices, try to match them up with what actually happened in the stimulus.

PT87 S3 Q8

Astronomer: Conditions in our solar system have probably favored the emergence of life more than conditions in most other solar systems of similar age. Any conceivable form of life depends on the presence of adequate amounts of chemical elements heavier than hydrogen and helium, and our sun has an unusually high abundance of these heavier elements of its age.

Which one of the following most accurately describes the role played in the astronomer's argument by the claim that any conceivable form of life depends on chemical elements heavier than hydrogen and helium?

A. It is a statement for which no evidence is provided and that is part of the evidence offered for the argument's only conclusion

B. It is a statement for which no evidence is provided and that is offered as support for another statement that in turn is offered as support for the conclusion of the argument as a whole

C. It is a statement for which some evidence is provided and that itself is offered as support for the conclusion of the argument as a whole

D. It is the conclusion of the argument as a whole and is supported by another statement for which support is offered

E. It is one of two conclusions in the argument, neither of which is offered as support for the other.

First things first, let's isolate the statement in question:

Astronomer: Conditions in our solar system have probably favored the emergence of life more than conditions in most other solar systems of similar age. **Any conceivable form of life depends on the presence of adequate amounts of chemical elements heavier than hydrogen and helium**, and our sun has an unusually high abundance of these heavier elements of its age.

Which one of the following most accurately describes the role played in the astronomer's argument by the claim that any conceivable form of life depends on chemical elements heavier than hydrogen and helium?

Now, let's go through the stimulus, reading for structure:

The first statement has the words "probably", indicating that it's an opinion of the author. The author believes that our solar system is better suited to life than other solar systems. Let's see why.

Statement 2 says that life needs a lot of chemicals heavier than hydrogen and helium, while statement 3 says that our solar system has plenty of both. Statements 2 and 3 are INDEPENDENT states supporting statement 1, the conclusion. There is no intermediate conclusion here.

A. It is a statement for which no evidence is provided and that is part of the evidence offered for the argument's only conclusion

Answer choice A says the underlined statement is a premise (no evidence provided), and the argument contains no intermediate conclusion (argument's only conclusion). Take a look at our stimulus, is it the premise that we are examining? Yes. Does the argument contain an intermediate conclusion? No.

B. It is a statement for which no evidence is provided and that is offered as support for another statement that in turn is offered as support for the conclusion of the argument as

a whole

Answer choice B also calls the underlined statement a premise, but according to this answer choice, there is an intermediate conclusion in the stimulus. Do we have an intermediate conclusion present? No. Earth having a lot of heavy elements does not support the fact that we need these elements to support life, nor does life needing heavy elements support the fact that the earth contains a lot of these elements.

C. It is a statement for which some evidence is provided and that itself is offered as support for the conclusion of the argument as a whole

C is essentially talking about an intermediate conclusion. Again, there is no intermediate conclusion in this stimulus.

D. It is the conclusion of the argument as a whole and is supported by another statement for which support is offered

Answer choice D is saying that the underlined statement is the main conclusion (it isn't), and that there is an intermediate conclusion in this stimulus/argument (there isn't).

E. It is one of two conclusions in the argument, neither of which is offered as support for the other.

Hmmm, interesting. Answer choice E is describing an interesting scenario. So there are two conclusions in the argument, but no intermediate conclusion. Take a look at the following example, that's what answer choice E is talking about:

> *To go to Yale Law School you need a high GPA and a high LSAT. John has been admitted to YLS. John has a high GPA and a high LSAT score.*

Two conclusions here: John has a high GPA, John has a high LSAT score. Neither of them are intermediate conclusions, having one doesn't mean you will more likely have the other.

The correct answer is A.

As we can see, having a clear understanding of the stimulus' structure is crucial to tackling Role questions. Furthermore, we also need to constantly practice our ability to decipher what each answer choice is saying and matching that up with the stimulus. In the hardest questions, sometimes it's not enough to simply identify the premise, intermediate conclusion and main conclusion, we must also read the answer choice word for word and refer back to the stimulus to prove or reject the answer based on the evidence available.

PT79 S1 Q22

Consumer advocate: Economists reason that price gouging – increasing the price of goods when no alternative seller is available – is efficient because it allocates goods to people whose willingness to pay more shows that they really need these goods. But willingness to pay is not proportional to need. In the real world, some people simply cannot pay as much as others. As a result, a price increase will allocate goods to people with the most money, not to those with the most need.

Which one of the following most accurately describes the role played in the consumer advocate's argument by the claim that willingness to pay is not proportional to need?

A. It disputes one explanation in order to make way for an alternative explanation

B. It is the overall conclusion of the argument

C. It is a component of reasoning disputed in the argument

D. It is a general principle whose validity the argument questions

E. It denies a claim that the argument takes to be assumed in the reasoning that it rejects

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The structure of this stimulus has tripped up countless students, let's break it down step by step:

Statement 1: *Economists reason that price gouging – increasing the price of goods when no alternative seller is available – is efficient because it allocates goods to people whose willingness to pay more shows that they really need these goods.*

This is an opposing argument, or what the consumer advocate is arguing against. What is the economists' argument?

If you are willing to pay more for a good, you must need it more. So price gouging is efficient. (The economists believe that allocating goods to those who need it the most is an efficient strategy)

Statement 2: *But willingness to pay is not proportional to need*

This is the consumer advocate's opinion. they are attacking the reasoning behind the economists' premise.

Statement 3: *In the real world, some people simply cannot pay as much as others*

On a first glance, how this statement ties in with the rest of the stimulus is a little bit unclear. Whenever I read a statement that seems to be disconnected from the rest of the information available, my first reaction is "so what?" If some people cannot pay as much as others, then the person needing something the most (for example, an urgent medical treatment) may not necessarily be able to offer the highest price for it. So in other words, statement 3 is supporting statement 2.

Statement 4: *As a result, a price increase will allocate goods to people with the most money, not to those with the most need.*

This is in direct opposition to the economists' reasoning, and therefore the consumer advocate's conclusion. Let's diagram this stimulus out:

Economists:

[If someone is willing to pay a higher price, that means they need it more] $\rightarrow$ [Price Gouging is Efficient]

Consumer Advocate:

[Some people just don't have money] $\rightarrow$ [Paying more doesn't mean you need it more] $\rightarrow$ [Price gouging benefits the rich, not those who need it the most]

So, structurally, statement 2 (*willingness to pay is not proportional to need*) is the consumer advocate's intermediate conclusion in his/her response to the economists. It's an attack on the economists' premise.

Let's look at the answer choices:

A. It disputes one explanation in order to make way for an alternative explanation

Tricky! Remember what the word "explanation" means on the LSAT? It has a very precise definition and means "causation". So what this answer choice is saying is that the author is disputing one cause in order to make way for another cause. If this is the correct answer, the stimulus would look something like this:

> John: A is caused by B
>
> David: No, A is not caused by B, it's caused by C

Does this happen in our stimulus? No. If the consumer advocate had said that price gouging is efficient NOT because it allocates goods to people whose willingness to pay more shows that they really need those goods; BUT that it is efficient because allows companies that make products people want to earn more profits and make better products, then this could potentially be the correct answer.

This is the most commonly selected wrong answer. The takeaway here is that we must get into the habit of reading answer choices word for word. Right off the bat, the word "explanation" should be a red flag, and if we dive deeper into this answer with a healthy dose of skepticism, we soon find more issues with it.

B. It is the overall conclusion of the argument

The overall conclusion is the last statement of the stimulus.

C. It is a component of the reasoning disputed in the argument

What the consumer advocate disputes is the second half of the first statement, namely the reasoning offered by the economists in support of their opposing view. The statement we are concerned with forms a part of the consumer advocate's reasoning.

D. It is a general principle whose validity the argument questions

Again, this statement is a part of the consumer advocate's argument, its validity is not questioned.

E. It denies a claim that the argument takes to be assumed in the reasoning that it rejects

As we have seen in the previous chapter, the correct answer will often be packaged in an abstract/vague way to throw the test taker off track. Many students will eliminate this answer simply because they had no idea what it's saying or failed to think on a deeper level what it's describing. Answer E is basically suggesting that there is an assumption in the economists' reasoning (the reason that it rejects), and that statement 2 ("willingness to pay is not proportional to need") is denying that assumption.

Does the economists' reasoning contain an assumption? Remember what the economists' argument was: if you are willing to pay more, it means you need it more, so price gouging is efficient. So the economists do believe that the willingness to pay IS proportional to need, a direct contradiction of statement 2.

E is the correct answer.

Let's look at another question where we must carefully consider each answer choice word for word. Take a look at the following question, after finding the structure of the argument, put your primary focus on the answer choices. For each answer choice, ask yourself, "does this happen in the stimulus? If so, where?"

PT59 S2 Q7

Columnist: It has been noted that attending a live musical performance is a richer experience than listening to recorded music. Some say that this is merely because we do not see the performers when we listen to recorded music. However, there must be some other reason, for there is relatively little difference between listening to someone read a story over the radio and listening to someone in the same room read a story.

Which one of the following most accurately expresses the role played in the argument by the observation that attending a live musical performance is a richer experience than is listening to recorded music?

A. It is what the columnist's argument purports to show

B. It is the reason given for the claim that the columnist's argument is attempting to undermine

C. It is what the columnist's argument purports to explain

D. It is what the columnist's argument purports to refute

E. It is what the position that the columnist tries to undermine is purported to explain

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Let's break down the stimulus:

Columnist: It has been noted that attending a live musical performance is a richer experience than listening to recorded music. Some say that this is merely because we do not see the performers when we listen to recorded music. However, there must be some other reason, for there is relatively little difference between listening to someone read a story over the radio and listening to someone in the same room read a story.

Which one of the following most accurately expresses the role played in the argument by the observation that attending a live musical performance is a richer experience than is listening to recorded music?

Statement 1 is an observation that the columnist makes ("it has been noted"). Let's keep on going.

Statement 2 presents one explanation (cause) for the observation made above.

Statement 3 is the columnist's conclusion, and the support they offer for it.

If we simplify the structure, we get something like this:

Statement 1: There is a phenomenon that has been noted (X)

Statement 2: Some believe X is caused by Y (Y$\Rightarrow$X)

Statement 3: X cannot be caused by Y (conclusion), because…(premise)

So the first statement is a scenario/phenomenon that the author is concerned with. It's not a part of the author's argument. The second statement is a classical opposing viewpoint. The author's argument comes in the last statement, in which they reject the cause offered by the people in the second statement and provides reasons for it.

Remember this example?

> John has lung cancer. Smoking causes lung cancer. Therefore John must be a smoker.

Compare and contrast this example with the stimulus, what are the similarities and differences between the two?

- **Similarities:** in both arguments, we start off with a phenomenon, and in both arguments, we attempt to find a cause to explain that phenomenon.
- **Differences:** in John's case, the author provides a cause for his lung cancer (smoking). In the stimulus, does the author provide a cause/explanation? No. The author's conclusion only rejects the cause offered by others, without going all the way to provide a cause/explanation of his own.

A. It is what the columnist's argument purports to show

Answer choice A is referring to the main conclusion of the argument. We know that in our stimulus, statement 1 is a phenomenon for which we are looking for the cause. It's not the main conclusion.

B. It is the reason given for the claim that the columnist's argument is attempting to undermine

This answer choice reverses the cause - effect relationship in our stimulus. In the stimulus, some people think that because we do see the performers when we listen to live music (cause) $\Rightarrow$ live music is a richer experience (effect). According to B, statement 1 is the reason for the view attacked by the columnist. So in other words, if we fully expand answer choice B, it should look like this:

Because attending a live musical performance is a richer experience, we do not see the performers when we listen to recorded music.

C. It is what the columnist's argument purports to explain

This is the most commonly selected wrong answer: read the keywords in the answer choice and ask yourself, does this happen in the stimulus? All correct answers will NEED to be matched with information in the stimulus.

Does the author explain (offer a cause) in their argument? Why is attending a live performance a richer experience? No, the author rejects another cause, but doesn't offer any new alternatives.

D. It is what the columnist's argument purports to refute

Does the author reject the observation that "attending a live musical performance is a richer experience than listening to recorded music?" No, the author doesn't. The author refutes an explanation for why this is the case, but doesn't reject the phenomenon itself.

E. It is what the position that the columnist tries to undermine is purported to explain

Two words: keyword extraction. When an answer choice is suspiciously vague and makes us run in circles in an attempt to understand its meaning, break it up into pieces and see if we can match it up with information from the stimulus.

"Position that the columnist tries to undermine" = because we do not see the performers when we listen to recorded music

What is this position purporting to explain? In other words, this position is a cause for what effect?

The effect is none other than the observation that "attending a live musical performance is a richer experience." Bingo.

The correct answer is E.

Sometimes it's not just the answer choices that are vague/abstract, stimuli and arguments can be too, and that brings us to:

> **Difficult Trait #3:** Role questions are famous for brutally abstract stimuli/arguments. When faced with an abstract argument in the stimulus, don't be afraid to slow down, summarize each statement, and rearrange the information structurally.

PT 51 S3 Q23

Ethicist: It would be a mistake to say that just because someone is not inclined to do otherwise, she or he does not deserve to be praised for doing what is right. For although we do consider people especially virtuous if they successfully resist a desire to do what is wrong, they are certainly no less virtuous if they have succeeded in extinguishing all such desires.

The assertion that people are considered especially virtuous if they successfully resist a

desire to do what is wrong plays which one of the following roles in the ethicist's argument?

A. It is a claim for which the argument attempts to provide justification

B. It makes an observation that, according to the argument, is insufficient to justify the claim that the argument concludes is false

C. It is a claim, acceptance of which, the argument contends, is a primary obstacle to some people having an adequate conception of virtue

D. It is, according to the argument, a commonly held opinion that is nevertheless false

E. It reports an observation that, according to the argument, serves as evidence for the truth of its conclusion